

Familiar Guest

Direct booking, made effortless for everyday rental owners

Familiar Guest is the simplest way for individual vacation rental owners to take bookings directly from their own trusted guests — without surrendering 15% and the guest relationship to Airbnb.

Owners create a listing in minutes, sync their calendar, and share a branded booking link. Payments, rental agreements, and trust protections are handled automatically. The guest never sees our brand — only the owner's.

The Opportunity

\$65–70B

U.S. & MEXICO RENTAL MARKET

25–30%

BOOKINGS FROM REPEAT GUESTS

\$9–13B

DIRECT-BOOKABLE VOLUME

- **Airbnb's 15.5% host fee** and the loss of guest contact information create a strong financial and relational motive for owners to go direct with guests they already know.
- **Airbnb's AirCover does not apply off-platform**, leaving a trust gap that casual tools (Venmo, email) cannot fill. Familiar Guest closes that gap.
- **Existing direct-booking tools are built for professional operators.** OwnerRez, Lodgify, and Hostaway require significant setup and technical comfort. No one cleanly serves the casual owner who just wants to take repeat guests direct.

How It Works

An owner goes from zero to a live booking link in under an afternoon:

1. **Create your listing** — Upload photos from your phone or cloud storage (Google Photos, iCloud, Dropbox). Paste your own description or answer a few questions and let AI write one for you.

- 2. Sync your calendar** — Connect your Airbnb, VRBO, or any platform calendar via iCal. Availability stays current automatically.
- 3. Verify your identity** — A quick, Stripe-powered check (most owners clear in under five minutes). This is what earns the "Verified Owner" badge your guests see.
- 4. Share your link** — Text it, email it, post it. Your guest books, signs the rental agreement, and pays — all in one flow, on their phone.

No website to build. No software to learn. No guest account required.

Trust — The Core Differentiator

Direct booking between individuals has always had a trust problem. Familiar Guest solves it with infrastructure that neither Venmo nor a personal website can offer:

Protection	What it does
Escrow	Guest funds are held until check-in — not released early. Neither party can disappear with the money.
Verified Owner	Every owner is identity-verified through Stripe as a condition of receiving payouts.
Rental Agreement	Auto-generated per booking, digitally signed, permanently stored. No PDF email chains.
Damage Deposit	Held separately, released automatically after the owner's inspection window.
Guest Screening	Optional ID and fraud check for bookings from guests the owner doesn't yet know.

Escrow is the single most important trust feature. It transforms "send money to a stranger" into "your funds are protected until you arrive."

Plans & Pricing

All owners must pass identity verification before listing a property or collecting payment. Card processing fees are passed through at cost on every plan — we never mark them up.

Plan	Price	Best for
Pay-as-you-go	5% per booking + payment fees	Seasonal or low-volume owners testing direct booking
Starter	\$15/month — 1 property, no commission	Single-home owners
Host	\$29/month — up to 5 properties, no commission	Active owners with multiple homes
Pro	\$49/month — 6-10 properties, no commission	Owners with several homes

All plans are subject to payment processing fees (card + currency conversion), passed through at cost.

Optional add-ons

Add-on	Price	What you get
Guest Screening	\$5 per booking	ID verification + fraud check
Protected Booking	\$19.99 per booking	Screening + up to \$1M damage protection

Crossover point: An owner booking more than ~\$3,600/year through Familiar Guest saves money by switching from Pay-as-you-go (5%) to the \$15/month Starter plan, then to Host when they add a second property.

Competitive Position

Competitor	Their approach	Where we differ
Airbnb	15.5% host fee, owns the guest relationship	We charge 5% or flat monthly; the owner keeps the guest relationship

OwnerRez	Powerful but complex; no native payments	We're live in an afternoon with payments built in
Lodgify	Website builder — owner drives their own traffic	We focus on repeat guests, not SEO
Hospitable	OTA automation; direct booking is a paid add-on	Direct booking is our core product, not a bolt-on
Houfy	Fee-free discovery marketplace	We're a trust layer for known guests, not a marketplace

Our lane: effortless setup, repeat-guest focus, trust built in by default, and **cross-border tax payments & accounting handled for the owner** — a combination no incumbent offers.

Financial Projections

Re-modeled on the Starter/Host/Pro pricing (blended ARPU ~\$218) with realistic operating costs and Mexican taxes & cross-border fees factored in. Full detail in the v2 financial model.

Revenue & Profitability

Metric	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Avg active owners	250	2,000	7,500
Active owners (year-end)	600	3,500	12,000
Blended ARPU	\$218	\$218	\$218
Revenue	\$54,500	\$436,000	\$1,635,000
Gross profit (76% margin)	\$41,420	\$331,360	\$1,242,600
Operating expenses (incl. cross-border compliance)	\$41,000	\$212,000	\$675,000
Operating profit	\$420	\$119,360	\$567,600
Operating margin	1%	27%	35%

Taxes, fees & cross-border costs — how they're treated

- **Owner rental taxes are pass-through, not our revenue.** Mexican income tax (ISR), VAT (IVA 16%), and the state lodging tax (ISH ~3%) are the owner's obligation; where required, Familiar Guest withholds and remits them to SAT on the owner's behalf. They do not inflate the figures above. (US homes: owner income tax + local occupancy/TOT handled the same way.)
- **IVA on our own service fee (Mexico)** is added to the owner's invoice and remitted — net-zero to us. *Downside risk:* if it must be absorbed rather than passed on, it would cut ~14% from Mexico-sourced service revenue.
- **Payment processing & currency conversion** are passed through at cost (net-zero). A modest optional FX spread is potential upside (see v2 model), not assumed here.
- **Cross-border compliance is a real cost** — Mexican SAT registration, Mexican accounting, and withholding administration — and is carried as an explicit operating-expense line (below).

Where the money goes

Category	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Infrastructure (hosting, database, domain)	\$600	\$3,000	\$12,000
SaaS services (e-signatures, monitoring, misc)	\$900	\$4,000	\$12,000
AI & development tools (incl. AI support/translation)	\$1,500	\$3,000	\$8,000
Professional services (contract dev, legal, insurance, accounting)	\$12,000	\$20,000	\$40,000
Cross-border tax & compliance (MX SAT/RFC, Mexican accounting, withholding admin)	\$6,000	\$15,000	\$35,000
Marketing & acquisition	\$5,000	\$35,000	\$100,000
Customer support (AI-deflected + nearshore)	\$15,000	\$132,000	\$468,000
Total	\$41,000	\$212,000	\$675,000

Roughly breakeven in Year 1, solidly profitable in Years 2-3. Customer support is the dominant cost at scale — held sublinear with AI-first, nearshore support. A small buffer (covering Year-1 legal, Mexican compliance setup, and support ramp) is prudent, but no large raise is required. The biggest swing factor remains support cost per owner.

Key assumptions

- Blended ARPU of ~\$218/active owner/year (mix of 5% commission and the \$15 Starter / \$29 Host / \$49 Pro plans). Mix and ARPU to be validated with real owners; a Host-leaning mix would raise ARPU.
- 76% gross margin after Stripe platform fees, hosting, third-party APIs, and cross-border payment/vendor costs.
- Mexican rental taxes (ISR/IVA/ISH) and US occupancy taxes are pass-through (not revenue); cross-border compliance is carried as an explicit OpEx line.
- Customer support is the largest cost at scale — held sublinear via AI-first deflection + nearshore (Mexico) support; growth driven mainly by referrals.
- Revenue calculated on average active owners per year.

Illustrative projections, not guarantees. The Mexican tax/withholding structure and the plan mix must be validated with counsel and real owners; both can move these numbers materially.

Risks — Honest Assessment

- **Adoption inertia.** Repeat guests may rebook on Airbnb out of habit. Converting them requires the booking link to be easier than what they already do.
 - **Calendar dependency.** Calendar sync relies on Airbnb's iCal feed, which Airbnb controls and could restrict. Listing content is owner-provided and has no platform dependency.
 - **Trust execution.** The differentiation rests on escrow, verification, and screening working flawlessly. A single high-profile failure would undercut the core promise.
 - **Cross-border tax exposure.** Mexico may require Familiar Guest to register with SAT and withhold/remit ISR and IVA on host earnings as a digital platform. This must be resolved with Mexican counsel before live Mexican payments; it can affect structure, cost, and timing.
 - **Support cost at scale.** A money-handling, cross-border product is support-heavy; if support scales linearly with owners it can erode margin. Mitigated by AI-first deflection and nearshore support.
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Next Steps

1. **Validate with 30–50 target owners** — confirm the share of bookings that are repeat guests and willingness to take them direct.
 2. **Build the core** — owner-driven listing creation, iCal calendar sync, Stripe-verified onboarding, branded booking link, and payments with escrow.
 3. **Launch in trusted-guest mode** in one beachhead niche; add public bookings and screening once retention is proven.
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